

Ethics Essay

The idea of having a “Code of Ethics” seems self-explanatory when asked about it’s purpose outright, however, when analyzed more this question has a lot more nuance than previously thought. The whole purpose of a “Code of Ethics” is to keep a foundation of what is morally correct under a certain jurisdiction. The IEEE code of ethics, for example, while have some ethics that could be applied to elsewhere, are moral guidelines that should apply to those in the field of electronics and electrical engineers. These codes are to ensure that what happens under the banner of IEEE does more good than harm in any scenario. While being a good person seems like an obvious thing, sometimes we as people are faced with morally ambiguous scenarios where what we do isn’t exactly good. Thus, a “Code of Ethics” is there to not only help make the best decisions in a scenario like that, but to help minimize the occurrence of those types of scenarios in general.

When faced with an ethical situation, I personally think about what outcome would minimize the most harmful outcomes. I try to find the most favorable outcome of not me, but everyone involved. I’m fortunate to have not experienced any big ethical dilemmas in my life, so there have usually been outcomes where everyone is happy and no one is harmed. That being said, I know that in the future that won’t always be the case and I will have to make tougher decisions in the future. When that time comes, if I am under a “Code of Ethics” I will do my best to follow those codes given the situation, however if this decision must be made without a code then I will do what I have been doing and look for the outcome that hurts the least amount of people.

One ethical issue we discussed was a text called the “BIG DATA ISSUE” which was a hypothetical situation in which a guy named Marcus is given some data from a higher up, John, that has sensitive information and if used would be unethical but could cost him the project since Marcus works for John and John wants the data. We based most of our conclusions on the IEEE Code of Ethics since this was a electronic based issue, and mostly agreed on the what codes were being breeched. Something that I brought up that wasn’t thought of initially in the scenario was the 10th code which was about supporting colleagues and co-workers in professional development and in following the code of ethics. It brought a new level of complexity to the situation, showing how hard these ethical decisions can be when considering all the factors. In the end, we were able to a most “ethical” decision, however I think it would have been for Marcus to not go through with the adding the data John wanted and for him to talk with John about it. This would violate the least amount of ethical codes set by the IEEE and harm the least amount of people, unfortunately risking Marcus’s position in the project.

When reflecting on the “Six Virtues of Ethics,” in regards to the hypothetical previously

discussed, I think the most applicable are; Responsibility, Integrity, and Self-Discipline. I think that when making this ethical decision, Marcus's judgements will be majorly influenced by these three virtues. Will he be responsible in his moral obligation to act for the good of others, in this case not using the data that will compromise the identity of many individuals or will he take responsibility if he decides to go through with what John wants? Will he have the integrity to hold true to moral principles as he did previously in the scenario and do what is right? Will he have the Self-Discipline to hold true to his moral and ethical obligations even though it could cost him his position on the project. While these may seem very similar in nature, they all tackle different aspects of Marcus's character. Self-Discipline looks at Marcus during the decision-making process, Integrity looks at him before the decision to see what kind of person Marcus is, and Responsibility looks at him either as a whole or after the decision has been made to see if he can hold true to whatever he decides. While the other virtues are important, I don't think any of them relate to this scenario as much or at all in some cases. Honesty feels similar to responsibility in this scenario, where he needs to be honest with himself to do what is right. Fidelity is a little more related, as Marcus as to go against his employer which would question his fidelity, however that is if he chooses to not add the data John wants, but if he did it would be a sign of his strong fidelity, at the cost of his integrity, responsibility, and self-discipline depending on the person Markus us. Lastly, Charity is about voluntarily helping others which I don't think applies at all in given situation.